> WOULD IT NOT BE A SHAME TO HAVE THE FLEET REMAIN INTACT WHILE OUR NATION PERISHES? ... YOU MUST ALL OF YOU REMEMBER THAT THERE ARE SUCH THINGS AS MIRACLES.
>
> **ADMIRAL TAKEO KURITA** BRIEFING HIS OFFICERS BEFORE THE BATTLE OF LEYTE GULF

northward, accepting the bait offered by Ozawa's carrier force. Communication between the two American commanders was poor and Kinkaid mistakenly thought Halsey had left part of his fleet covering the northern flank of the invasion force. He had not. Meanwhile, Kinkaid sent most of his warships south to meet Admiral Shoji Nishimura's two battleships, cruiser, and four destroyers coming through the Surigao Strait.

Emerging from the strait in the early hours of October 25, the Japanese ships were ambushed by US destroyers firing a total of 27 torpedoes and sinking the battleship *Fuso* and three destroyers.

1885–1966

CHESTER NIMITZ

COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF OF PACIFIC NAVAL FORCES



Born in Texas into a family of German origin, Chester Nimitz graduated from the US Naval Academy in 1905. After earning a reprimand as a young ensign for running a destroyer aground, he transferred to submarines and during World War I acted as chief of staff of the US Atlantic Submarine Force. Promoted to rear admiral in 1938, he was chief of the Bureau of Navigation when the Japanese attacked Pearl Harbor. Ten days later he was appointed commander-in-chief of the Pacific Fleet. During a period of Japanese naval superiority, Nimitz followed an aggressive strategy based on calculated risk. This bore fruit in the crucial victory at Midway in 1942. He masterminded the subsequent "island-hopping" drive through the Central Pacific toward Japan. Nimitz was appointed a fleet admiral in 1944 and was a signatory at the Japanese surrender ceremony in Tokyo Bay in October 1945.



Landings at Leyte Gulf
Two Coast Guard-manned LSTs (Landing Ships Tank) open their jaws onto Leyte Beach. While the landings themselves were not strongly opposed, the Japanese Navy later threw all the forces they had left against the invading forces.

